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24/7 Markets: QFEX, Part 1

® **Abstract:** QFEX is the first centralised 24/7 perpetual futures exchange on traditional assets like US equities, commodities, and FX. QFEX introduces the derivatives structure that captures ~90% of crypto derivatives volume to TradFi. This paper is the first in a three-part series examining the shift towards continuous markets.

Futures on traditional assets – index, commodity, rates, and FX contracts – are traded on exchanges like CME, ICE, and Eurex with regulated CLOBs. These exchanges operate on a 23/5 schedule, offer dated futures contracts which require periodic roll, and deliver roughly 15-25x leverage margins on liquid contracts.

QFEX challenges the existing system: the dated, cash/physically-settled futures contract is an artifact of pre-digital markets. They take the crypto approach towards perps, providing direct access to continuous trading. Perps keep mark-to-index tighter via the funding mechanism and trade continuously, so overnight information gets priced in as it arrives rather than accumulating to the next open.

This approach is championed by crypto CEXs like Binance, Bybit, OKX, and DEXs like Hyperliquid and Aster. Binance alone processed ~\$25tn in perp volume in 2025 at ~30% market share, with Bybit and OKX each commanding 13-21%. Perps won in crypto because the funding-rate mechanism delivers continuous leverage exposure without the operational friction of quarterly roll.

QFEX runs its own CLOB, where it offers US equities, indices, commodities, and FX, traded as USDC-margined perpetual futures. Brokerless trading is allowed 24/7, with leverage up to 100x, comparable to crypto perp exchanges. QFEX bets that perpetual futures is the cleanest product for continuous TradFi exposure: a single contract, no expiry, no rollover, funded hourly. One unresolved vulnerability is QFEX's "oracle pricing" mechanism, which is responsible for pricing assets when the underlying spot market is closed. The accuracy with which weekend QFEX prices can predict Monday open will play a big role in determining how much institutional flow will end up on QFEX.

Continuous risk transfer will reshape close-to-open jump distributions – a first-order input in GARCH models and overnight-reversion signals – for with liquid continuous listings, as QFEX absorbs overnight information flow. Another QFEX feature is its 100ms limit-order speed bump, which prevents latency arbitrage, shifting alpha towards signal and queue modelling.

Though launching six weeks ago, QFEX has not published volume statistics and still operates an access waitlist, likely indicating that trading volumes remain below the threshold at which the company would benefit from disclosure. The big question for the next 12-18 months is not whether QFEX survives, but whether it captures enough off-hours flow before Nasdaq 23/5 launches.

QFEX is the most recent answer to the 24/7 trading question, with the ambition of one day replacing the \$100bn exchange, brokerage, and clearing industry. Crypto markets act as a proof of concept, but QFEX is not the only one in the running. Nasdaq 23/5 and NYSE Arca 22/5 (pending approvals) could close the gap fast once they go live. In upcoming parts, we will continue covering the push towards continuous trading markets, to answer one question: what does it mean for quants?

Chart 1

Feature	TradFi	QFEX
Expiry	Quarterly	None
Hours	23/5 (CME)	24/7
Leverage	~20x (SPAN)	Up to 100x
Access	Broker + FCM + CCP	Direct
Currency	Cash USD at FCM	USDC on Arbitrum

Source: Prometheus Capital

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